

A GIFT FROM YOUR PIANO TEACHER

The Adult Beginner’s Piano Starter Guide

Seven first steps, taught the way musicians are taught

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A NOTE FROM YOUR TEACHER

Welcome to the piano.

If you are reading this, some part of you has wanted to play the piano for a long time. It is not too late, and you do not need “talent.” What you need is to start the right way, because you have one pair of hands, and it is far easier to learn a movement correctly the first time than to unlearn it later.

I was trained in the Russian school of piano playing, in Moscow, by teachers who were themselves taught by the great pianists of the last century. In this guide I will teach you the way musicians are taught: how to sit, where the sound comes from, and how to practice, from your very first note. There is no jargon here that I do not explain.

Dr. Maria Pisarenko

STEP 1

Set up properly

You need an 88-key keyboard with fully **weighted** keys, or an acoustic piano, so that your fingers and arm learn what a real key feels like, and a bench or chair whose height you can change. My recommendations for instruments and books are here: onlinepianouniversity.com/books.html.

STEP 2

Sit high enough

Sit at the middle of the keyboard, upright, without leaning on the back of the chair, shoulders down. Now look at your arm: the **elbow should be level with the wrist or slightly above it, never below**. If your elbow hangs lower than your wrist, you are sitting too low, and the weight of your arm cannot reach the keys. The fix is the seat, not the arm: put a firm cushion or a few books on the bench until the elbow is at or a little above the wrist.

STEP 3

Let the hand live in the keys

Keep the hand rounded, as though holding an apple, and play on the tip of each finger, with the first joint firm rather than collapsing. Do not play at the very front edge of the white keys: bring the hand further in, so the fingers sit **between the black keys**. How deep depends on the music; the hand belongs in the keyboard, not at its edge.

STEP 4

Make your first sound with the arm, not the finger

A piano tone is made by a hammer thrown at the string. What controls it is the speed of the key, and that should come from the **weight of the arm dropping into the key**, not from a finger pushing. Try one note with your third finger: let the relaxed arm fall into the key, then listen to the sound until it has completely faded. A pushed note sounds hard and dies early; a note played with the weight of the arm rings.

STEP 5

Find your way around the keyboard

The black keys come in groups of two and three. **C** is the white key just to the left of every group of two; **F** is just to the left of every group of three. From C and F you can name every white key, A to G, and the pattern repeats across the whole keyboard. Your fingers are numbered from the thumb (1) to the little finger (5) in both hands. Follow the printed fingering exactly, but **play the note, not the finger**: the fingering tells you how to move, the note is what sounds.

STEP 6

See it, hear it, then play it

Before your hands go to the keys, look at the music and hear in your head how it should sound. A quarter note lasts one count, a half note two, a whole note four, and holding each one its full length is half of playing well. Learn every new piece in this order: **slowly first; then naming the notes aloud; then counting aloud; and only then at tempo**. For note-reading practice away from the piano, use my free app: mariapisarenko.com/app.

STEP 7

Follow a real course, in order

Random videos give random progress. My free 41-lesson beginner course on YouTube takes you step by step, in order, from your first note. Start with Lesson 1: onlinepianouniversity.com/free-course.html, or open the full playlist on YouTube: youtube.com/playlist (Online Piano University course).

A 15-MINUTE DAILY ROUTINE

A little every day

- **3 minutes:** warm the hands (make firm fists, then open the fingers wide, five times, breathing slowly), then play a few single notes with the weight of the arm and listen to each one.
- **7 minutes:** the one place in your piece that does not work yet, very slowly, each hand separately, then joined back into the phrase.
- **5 minutes:** play something you already enjoy, from beginning to end, listening to the sound.

Fifteen focused minutes every day will take you further than two hours once a week.

FOUR HABITS TO AVOID

What holds adult beginners back

- Sitting too low, with the elbow below the wrist.
- Pushing the keys with the fingers instead of letting the arm's weight make the sound.
- Playing faster than you can hold every note its full value. Slow and correct is faster in the end.
- Putting the hands together too soon. Learn each hand on its own first.

PERSONAL FEEDBACK

Send me your playing

When you practice any of the 41 lessons of my free course, you can **record yourself and send it to me**. You will receive written feedback by email: what is already working, what to correct first, and exactly how to practice it.

- **Audio alone is enough**: a simple phone recording beside your piano.
- Want feedback on your hand position too? Film **just your hands**; your face is never required.
- Send it here: onlinepianouniversity.com/submit.html.

Do not wait until it is perfect. Mistakes are exactly what feedback is for.

ABOUT YOUR TEACHER

Who is teaching you?

I began the piano at five in Siberia and played my first solo recital at seven. I was trained at the Central Music School of the Moscow Tchaikovsky Conservatory and at the Gnessin Russian Academy of Music, and I earned my Doctor of Musical Arts in Piano Performance in the United States.

- **Doctor of Musical Arts (DMA)**, Piano Performance
- **International competition prizewinner**: Paris (Sviatoslav Richter) and Rome (Chopin)
- **Concert pianist**: Russia, Europe, Asia and the United States, including the Royal Academy of Music (London) and the Paris Conservatory
- **Steinway Top Teacher Award**
- Piano faculty at the College of Southern Nevada and Southern Utah University

YOUR NEXT STEP

Where to go from here

- **Start the free course** at Lesson 1: onlinepianouniversity.com/free-course.html
- **Subscribe on YouTube** so the next lesson is always in front of you: youtube.com/@ONLINEPIANOUNIVERSITY
- **Send me your playing** for free written feedback: onlinepianouniversity.com/submit.html
- **Practice reading notes** with my free app: mariapisarenko.com/app
- **Private lessons on Zoom**, if you would like me to guide you personally: onlinepianouniversity.com/lessons.html

Anyone can press the keys. My aim is that you really play: with a real foundation, a beautiful sound, and the right habits from your very first note. I look forward to hearing you.

With warm regards,
Dr. Maria Pisarenko

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